MANCHESTER UNITED PUBLIC-DATA RECRUITMENT SCREEN

Casemiro Replacement Profile

The next signing should not only win duels. It should prevent some of them from happening.

This is a public-data recruitment framework, not proprietary scouting data or a signing verdict.

Executive View

Palacios is the strongest possession-control candidate in the screen, not the strongest like-for-like Casemiro replacement. Cardoso is the cleaner two-axis defensive/security fit.

TOP WEIGHTED SCREEN

Exequiel Palacios

Score 73.8. Leads through control and progression, subject to defensive translation and availability review.

TWO-AXIS FIT

Johnny Cardoso

Defence 85.0, possession 71.4. More balanced defensive/security profile.

DEFENSIVE REFERENCE

63.3

Casemiro is a defensive responsibility reference, not the clone target.

Interpretation: The model starts the scouting conversation. It does not replace video, medical review, contract work, fee analysis, or tactical role evaluation.

What This Model Is — and Is Not

This is a recruitment screen, not a signing verdict. It converts United's abstract need for midfield control into a transparent, auditable public-data framework.

It is designed to focus scouting/video discussion. It does not replace club scouting, medical review, contract work, fee analysis, or tactical video.

How the Score Works

Formula: 30% defensive protection + 25% transition control + 25% possession security + 15% progressive value + 5% age / availability.

Each input metric is first converted into a comparable rate, percentage, or per-touch measure. It is then normalized into a 0-100 percentile-style score within the screened player pool. For negative events such as fouls, cards, miscontrols, dispossessions, and turnover rate, the score is inverted so that safer players receive higher values. Category scores are calculated as the average of available input-metric scores. The final Control Midfielder Score is a weighted average of the five category scores.

A 100 means the player is at the top of this public screened pool for that metric or category. It does not mean perfect football ability.

Why These Weights?

The weighting scheme reflects Manchester United's specific midfield-control problem. This is not a search for the best pure ball-winner. It is a search for a midfielder who can preserve enough defensive protection while improving control.

- **Defensive protection receives 30%**, the highest single weight, because any Casemiro replacement profile must still protect the back line, defend central spaces, and survive defensive responsibility.
- **Transition control receives 25%** because United's issue is not only settled defending; it is also the number of chaotic moments created after possession breaks.
- **Possession security receives 25%** because the deeper thesis is that United need control. A midfielder who loses possession too often will recreate the same emergency-defending problem even if he wins duels.
- **Progressive value receives 15%** because United still need the player to move the ball forward, but this role should not become a pure creator search.
- **Age / availability receives 5%** because practical squad-building context matters, but it should not overpower the football profile.

The weighting scheme is designed to reward midfielders who can defend first, stabilize transitions second, secure possession third, and progress the ball without turning the role into a high-risk creator profile.

These weights are subjective but transparent. That is why the report includes sensitivity analysis to test whether the shortlist collapses when reasonable weighting assumptions change.

Why Use a Defensive Gate?

A weight ranks players. A gate enforces a minimum requirement.

Even though defensive protection has the highest single weight, a player can still score highly overall if he is elite in possession security and progression. For a Casemiro replacement profile, that creates a risk: the model could surface elegant possession players who do not have enough defensive evidence to survive United's midfield environment.

The defensive gate should be read as a minimum-evidence filter, not as a final judgment on defensive ability. Palacios clears the defensive gate narrowly, so he should not be treated as a pure defensive replacement. Elliot Anderson falls just below the gate, so he should remain a watchlist player rather than be treated as definitively rejected.

This is why the report separates the published shortlist, borderline watchlist, and role-mismatch watchlist rather than deleting below-gate players entirely. Borderline differences around the gate should be tested with video, tactical role context, league translation, and team style.

From Input Metrics to Category Scores

Positive inputs reward higher raw values. Inverted inputs reward lower raw values, which matters for events like fouls, cards, miscontrols, dispossessions, and turnover rate. The table below shows the exact raw column, direction, and transformation used for every configured input.

Category	Input metric	Raw column	Direction	Transformation	Football meaning	Caveat
Defensive protection	Tackles Interceptions Per90	tackles_interceptions_per90	Positive input: higher raw value scores better	Percentile score	Captures ball-winning activity and defensive involvement.	Activity volume is role- and team-state dependent.
Defensive protection	Interceptions Per90	interceptions_per90	Positive input: higher raw value scores better	Percentile score	Captures anticipation and ability to cut passing lanes.	Can be inflated by teams defending deeper or without the ball.
Defensive protection	Dribblers Tackled Pct	dribblers_tackled_pct	Positive input: higher raw value scores better	Percentile score	Captures one-v-one defensive reliability.	Does not show how often a player is isolated.
Defensive protection	Blocks Per90	blocks_per90	Positive input: higher raw value scores better	Percentile score	Captures defensive presence in lanes and around the box.	Blocks can reflect exposure as much as quality.
Defensive protection	Aerial Duel Win Pct	aerial_duel_win_pct	Positive input: higher raw value scores better	Percentile score	Captures physical defensive floor.	Aerial volume and opponent targeting are not captured here.

Category	Input metric	Raw column	Direction	Transformation	Football meaning	Caveat
Defensive protection	Def Mid Third Actions Per90	def_mid_third_actions_per90	Positive input: higher raw value scores better	Percentile score	Captures activity in zones relevant to a deeper midfielder.	Zone definitions vary across public providers.
Transition control	Ball Recoveries Per90	ball_recoveries_per90	Positive input: higher raw value scores better	Percentile score	Captures ability to regain loose balls and stabilize broken play.	Recoveries are partly created by team pressing structure.
Transition control	Pressure Regains Per90	pressure_regains_per90	Positive input: higher raw value scores better	Percentile score	Captures whether the player helps stop counters early.	Public aggregate sources do not define pressure regains identically.
Transition control	Def Actions After Loss Per90	def_actions_after_loss_per90	Positive input: higher raw value scores better	Percentile score	Captures reaction immediately after possession changes.	Best treated as a proxy without full event-sequence context.
Transition control	Fouls Committed Per90	fouls_committed_per90	Inverted input: lower raw value scores better	Inverse percentile score	Lower is better; repeated fouling can indicate late control or transition stress.	Some tactical fouling is deliberate and context dependent.
Transition control	Cards Per90	cards_per90	Inverted input: lower raw value scores better	Inverse percentile score	Lower is better; discipline matters for a deeper midfielder.	Refereeing and league context affect card rates.
Transition control	Miscontrols Per90	miscontrols_per90	Inverted input: lower raw value scores better	Inverse percentile score	Lower is better; poor control can trigger transitions.	Miscontrol definitions vary by provider.

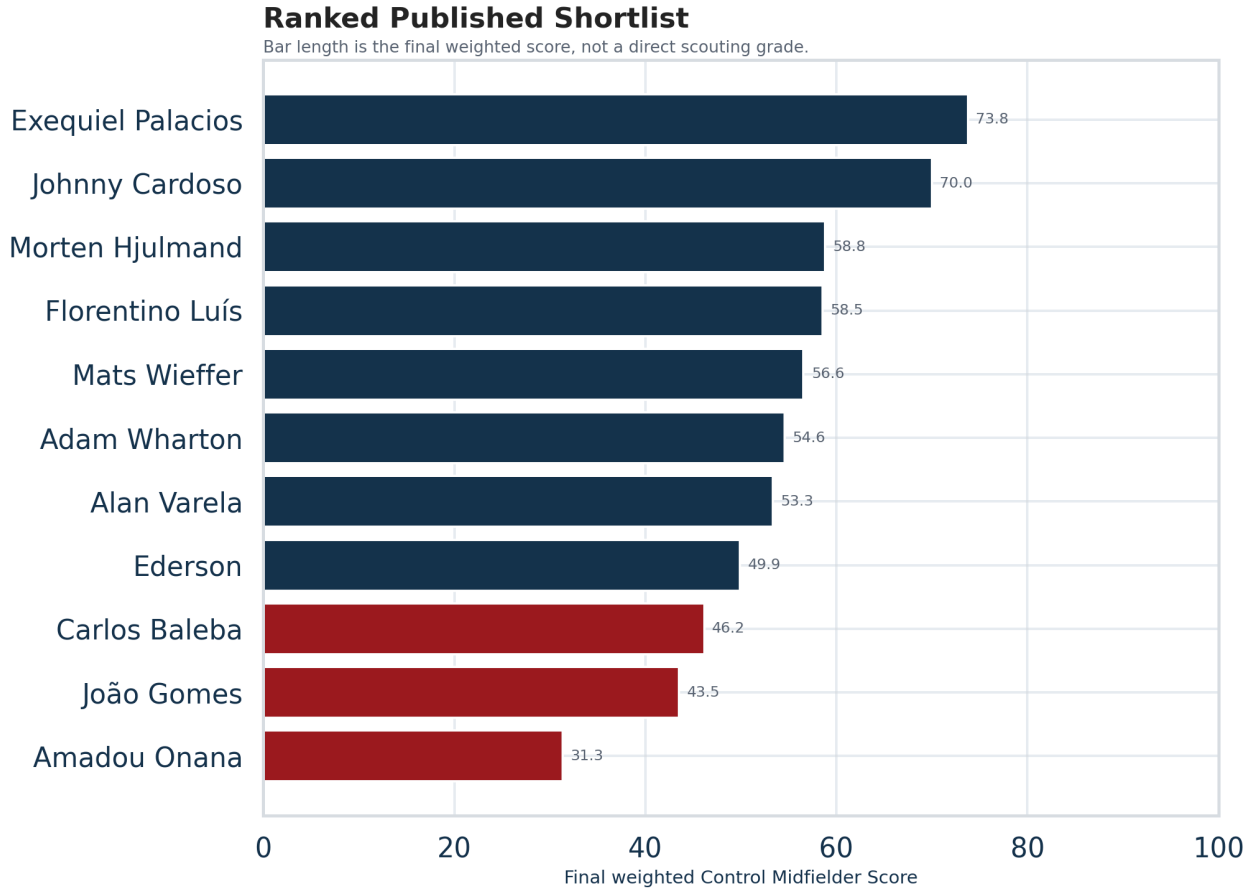
Category	Input metric	Raw column	Direction	Transformation	Football meaning	Caveat
Transition control	Dispossessed Per90	dispossessed_per90	Inverted input: lower raw value scores better	Inverse percentile score	Lower is better; being dispossessed in midfield creates defensive exposure.	High-touch players face more opportunities to be dispossessed.
Possession security	Pass Completion Pct	pass_completion_pct	Positive input: higher raw value scores better	Percentile score	Captures basic reliability in possession.	Completion rate does not separate easy passes from pressured passes.
Possession security	Short Medium Pass Completion Pct	short_medium_pass_completion_pct	Positive input: higher raw value scores better	Percentile score	Captures security in circulation phases.	Can be boosted by low-risk team structures.
Possession security	Passes Received Per90	passes_received_per90	Positive input: higher raw value scores better	Percentile score	Captures availability to receive and connect play.	Team possession share affects receiving volume.
Possession security	Touches Per90	touches_per90	Positive input: higher raw value scores better	Percentile score	Captures involvement and ability to stay connected to possession.	Volume should be paired with turnover safety.
Possession security	Dispossessed Per Touch	dispossessed_per_touch	Inverted input: lower raw value scores better	Inverse percentile score	Lower is better; captures ball security relative to involvement.	Does not identify pitch location of dispossessions.
Possession security	Miscontrols Per Touch	miscontrols_per_touch	Inverted input: lower raw value	Inverse percentile score	Lower is better; captures technical	Does not distinguish pressure level.

Category	Input metric	Raw column	Direction	Transformation	Football meaning	Caveat
			scores better		security under involvement.	
Possession security	Turnover Rate	turnover_rate	Inverted input: lower raw value scores better	Inverse percentile score	Lower is better; central midfield turnovers create transition risk.	Combines multiple public turnover proxies.
Progressive value	Progressive Passes Per90	progressive_passes_per90	Positive input: higher raw value scores better	Percentile score	Captures forward passing value.	Progressive pass definitions vary by source.
Progressive value	Progressive Carries Per90	progressive_carries_per90	Positive input: higher raw value scores better	Percentile score	Captures ability to move possession forward by carrying.	Carrying volume depends on role and team spacing.
Progressive value	Passes Into Final Third Per90	passes_into_final_third_per90	Positive input: higher raw value scores better	Percentile score	Captures territory-gaining passing.	Final-third entries do not measure pass difficulty.
Progressive value	Carries Into Final Third Per90	carries_into_final_third_per90	Positive input: higher raw value scores better	Percentile score	Captures territory-gaining carrying.	May favor players in more open transition systems.
Progressive value	Progressive Passing Distance Per90	progressive_passing_distance_per90	Positive input: higher raw value scores better	Percentile score	Captures volume and distance of forward passing.	Long-distance progression is not always better than secure circulation.
Progressive value	Live Ball Sca Per90	live_ball_sca_per90	Positive input: higher raw value	Percentile score	Low-weight proxy for useful possession contributio	This is not a creator search; it is only a

Category	Input metric	Raw column	Direction	Transformation	Football meaning	Caveat
			scores better		n near chance creation.	supporting signal.
Age / availability	Age Score	age_score	Positive input: higher raw value scores better	Percentile score	Rewards players in a more useful squad-building age band.	Age is a proxy, not a medical or developme nt projection.
Age / availability	Minutes Score	minutes_sc ore	Positive input: higher raw value scores better	Percentile score	Rewards players with enough recent minutes to make the signal more reliable.	Minutes do not replace injury-history or medical review.

Ranked Published Shortlist

The final score uses all five categories.

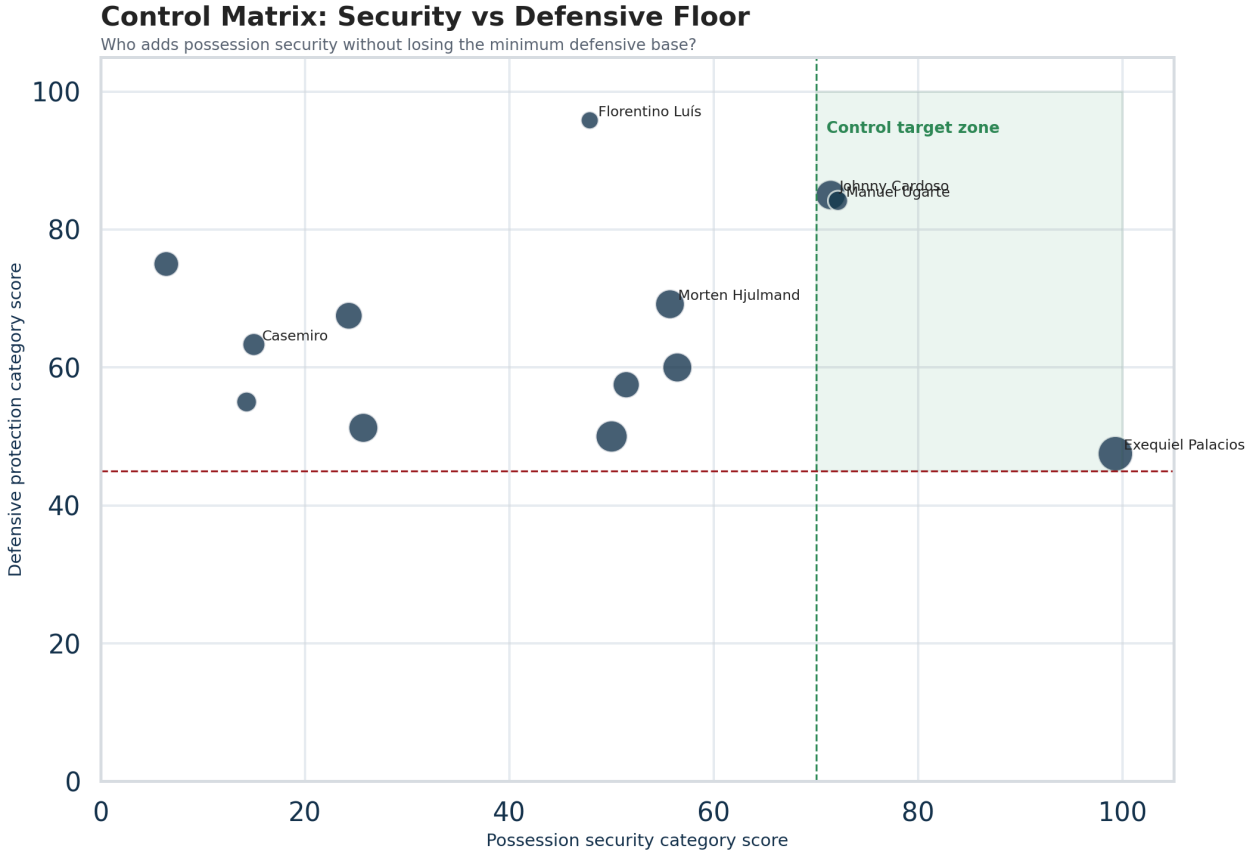


#	Player	Club	League	Age	Score	Defence	Transition	Security	Progression	Age / availability	Gate margin
1	Exequiel Palacios	Bayer Leverkusen	Bundesliga	27	73.77	47.50	79.29	99.29	85.83	40.00	2.50
2	Johnny Cardoso	Atlético Madrid	La Liga	24	70.00	85.00	63.57	71.43	57.50	42.50	40.00
3	Morten Hjulmand	Sporting CP	Primeira Liga	26	58.82	69.17	51.07	55.71	55.00	62.50	24.17
4	Florentino Luís	Burnley	Premier League	26	58.54	95.83	59.29	47.86	8.33	35.00	50.83
5	Mats Wieff	Brighton &	Premier	26	56.57	60.00	52.86	56.43	55.83	57.50	15.00

#	Player	Club	League	Age	Score	Defence	Transition	Security	Progression	Age / availability	Gate margin
	er	Hove Albion	League								
6	Adam Wharton	Crystal Palace	Premier League	22	54.61	50.00	61.43	50.00	67.50	32.50	5.00
7	Alan Varela	Porto	Primeira Liga	24	53.32	57.50	57.86	51.43	42.50	47.50	12.50
8	Ederson	Atalanta	Serie A	26	49.91	67.50	52.86	24.29	45.00	72.50	22.50
9	Carlos Baleba	Brighton & Hove Albion	Premier League	22	46.17	51.25	50.71	25.71	55.83	66.25	6.25
10	João Gomes	Wolverhampton Wanderers	Premier League	25	43.55	75.00	44.29	6.43	35.83	60.00	30.00
11	Amadou Onana	Aston Villa	Premier League	24	31.32	55.00	25.00	14.29	16.67	50.00	10.00

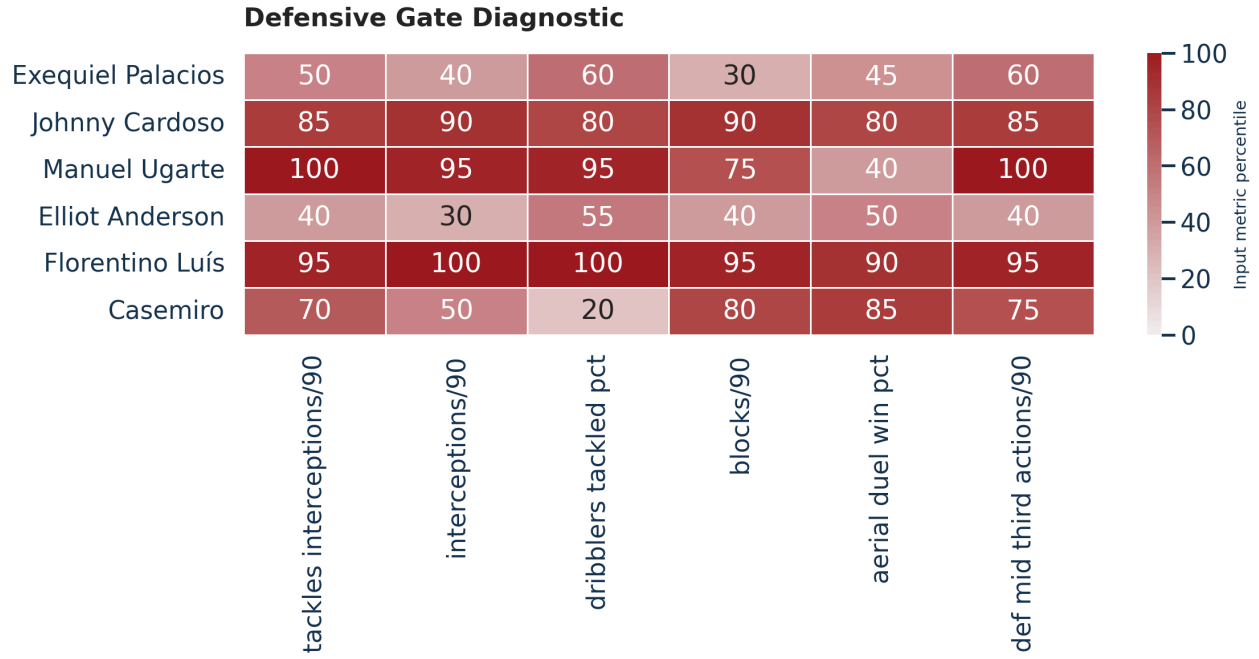
Control Matrix

Who adds possession security without losing the defensive floor?



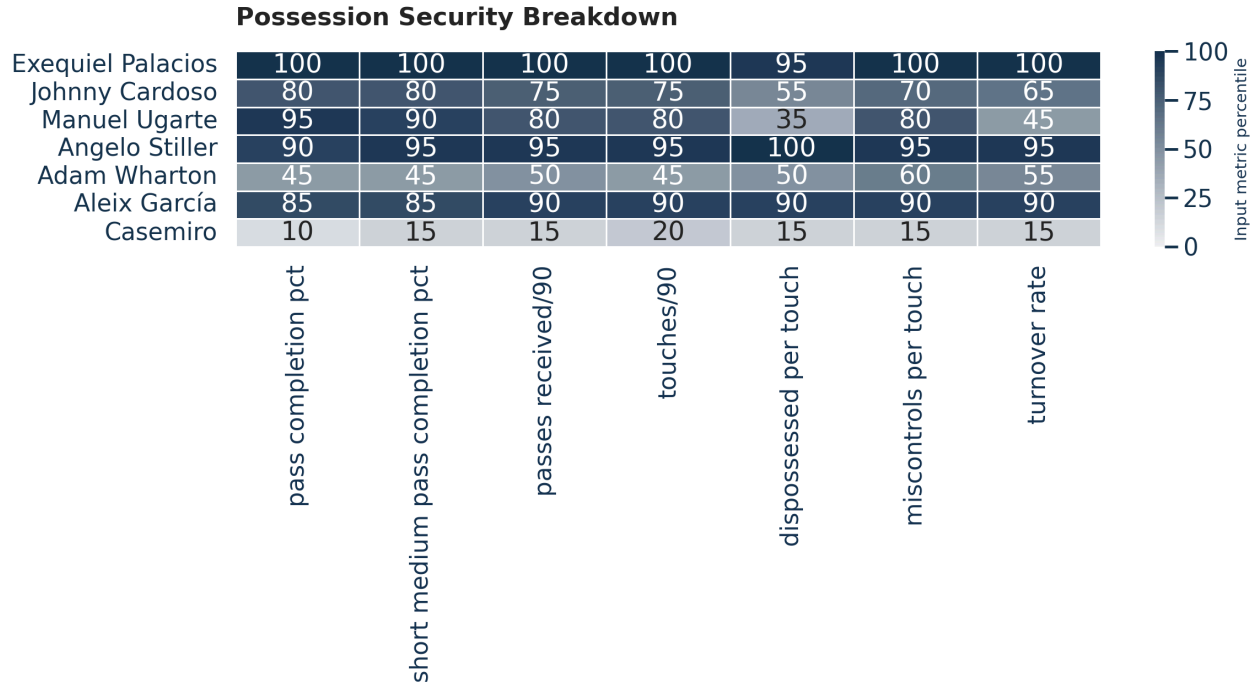
Defensive Gate Diagnostic

The gate is useful as a screen, but the Palacios-Anderson gap shows why borderline cases should not be treated as definitive scouting judgments.



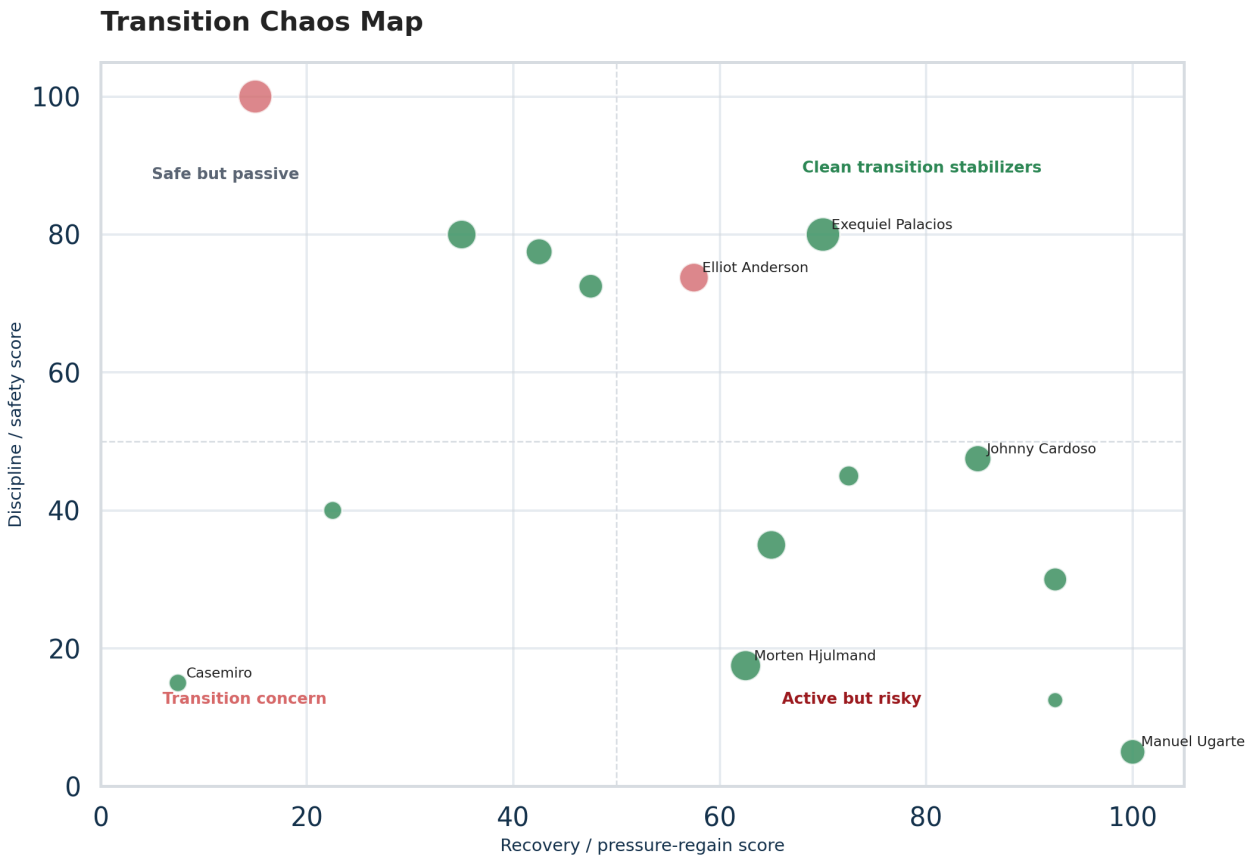
Possession Security Breakdown

This plot separates players who simply pass safely from players who are actively available, involved, and secure under volume.



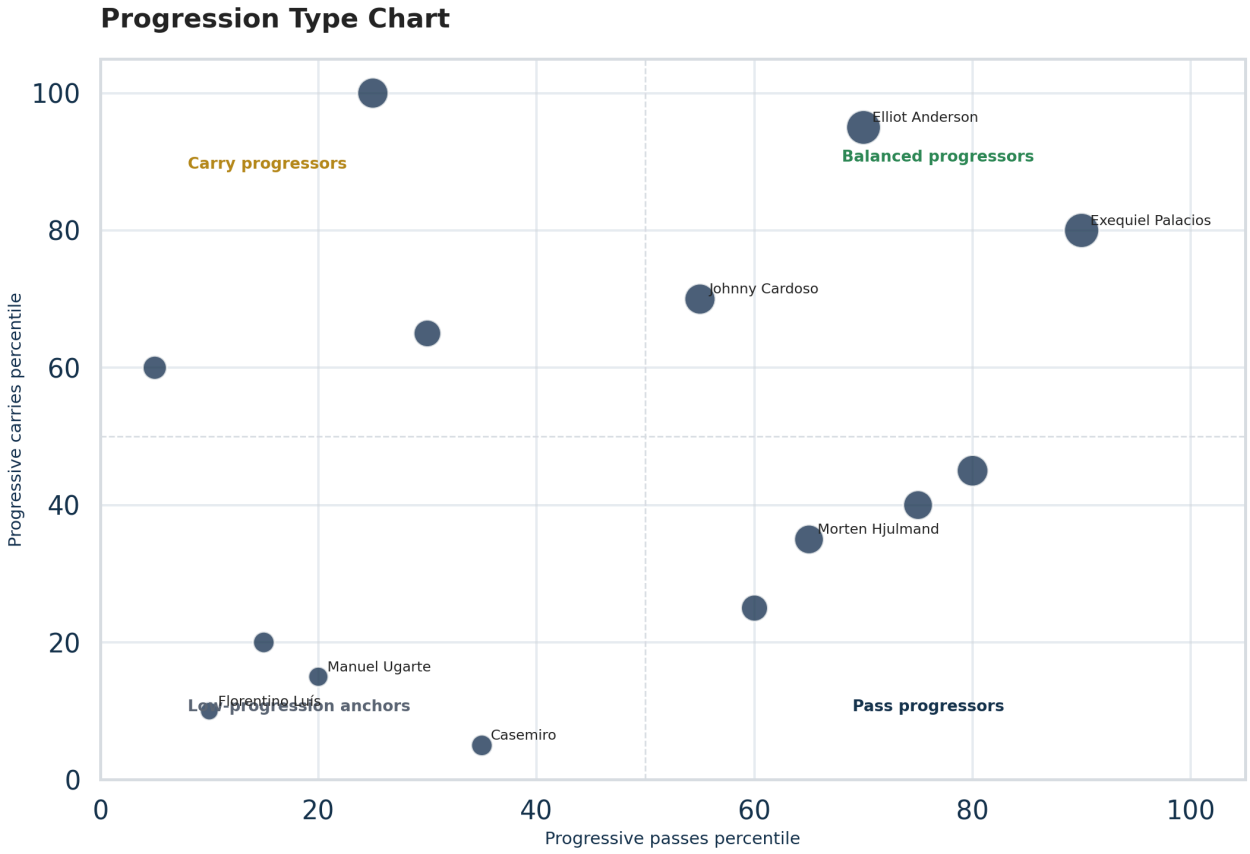
Transition Chaos Map

United's issue is not only ball-winning. It is the number of unstable moments after possession breaks. This chart highlights players who regain or stabilize play without creating new problems.



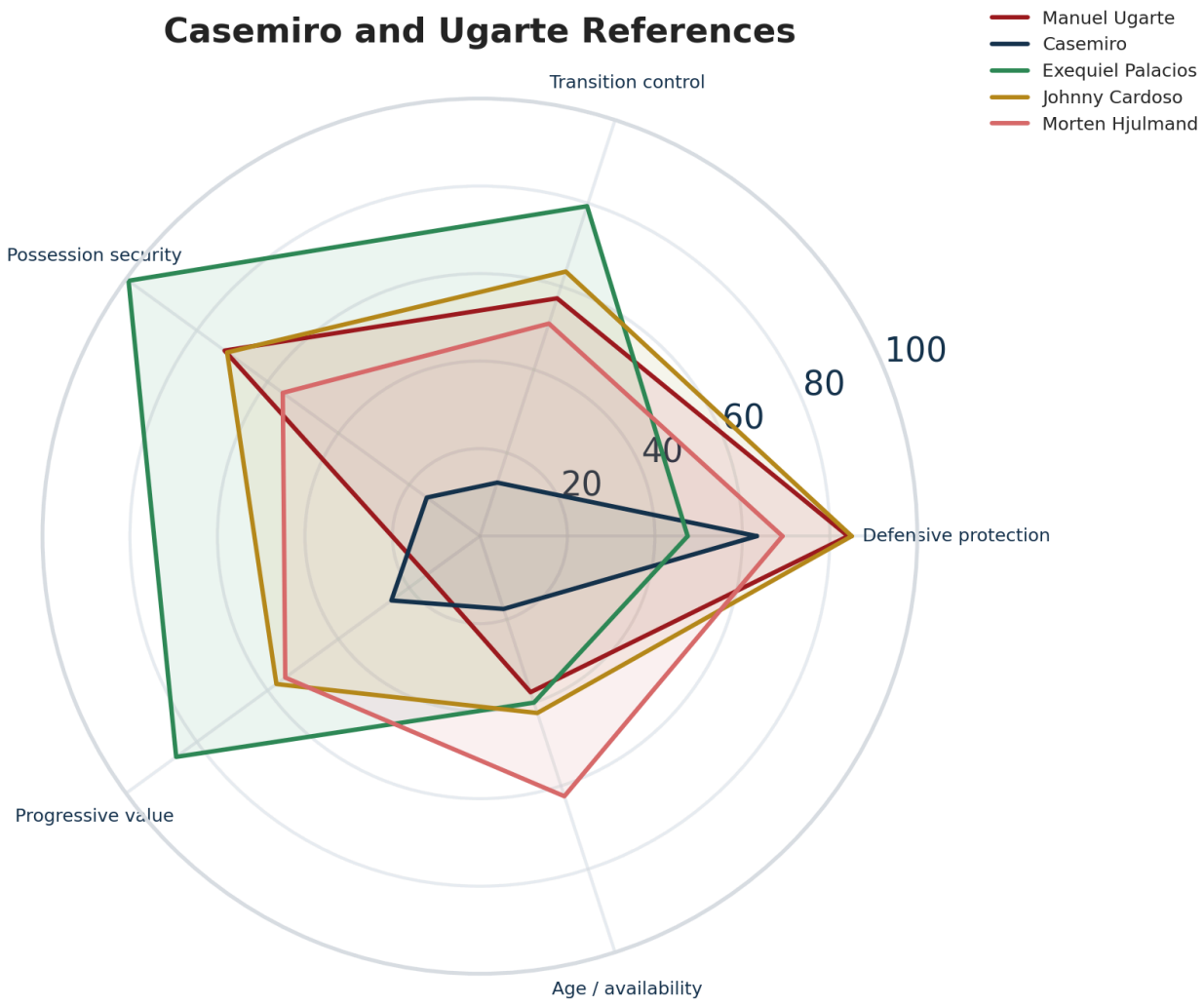
Progression Type

Progression is not one skill. Some midfielders move the ball through passing, others through carrying. United should know which type they are buying.



Reference Profiles: Casemiro and Ugarte

Casemiro and Ugarte are reference players, not targets in this screen. Casemiro is an ageing defensive responsibility reference, not the clone target. Ugarte already covers much of the defence/security base, but his low progression score suggests United may still need a complementary midfielder who can add control without limiting progression.



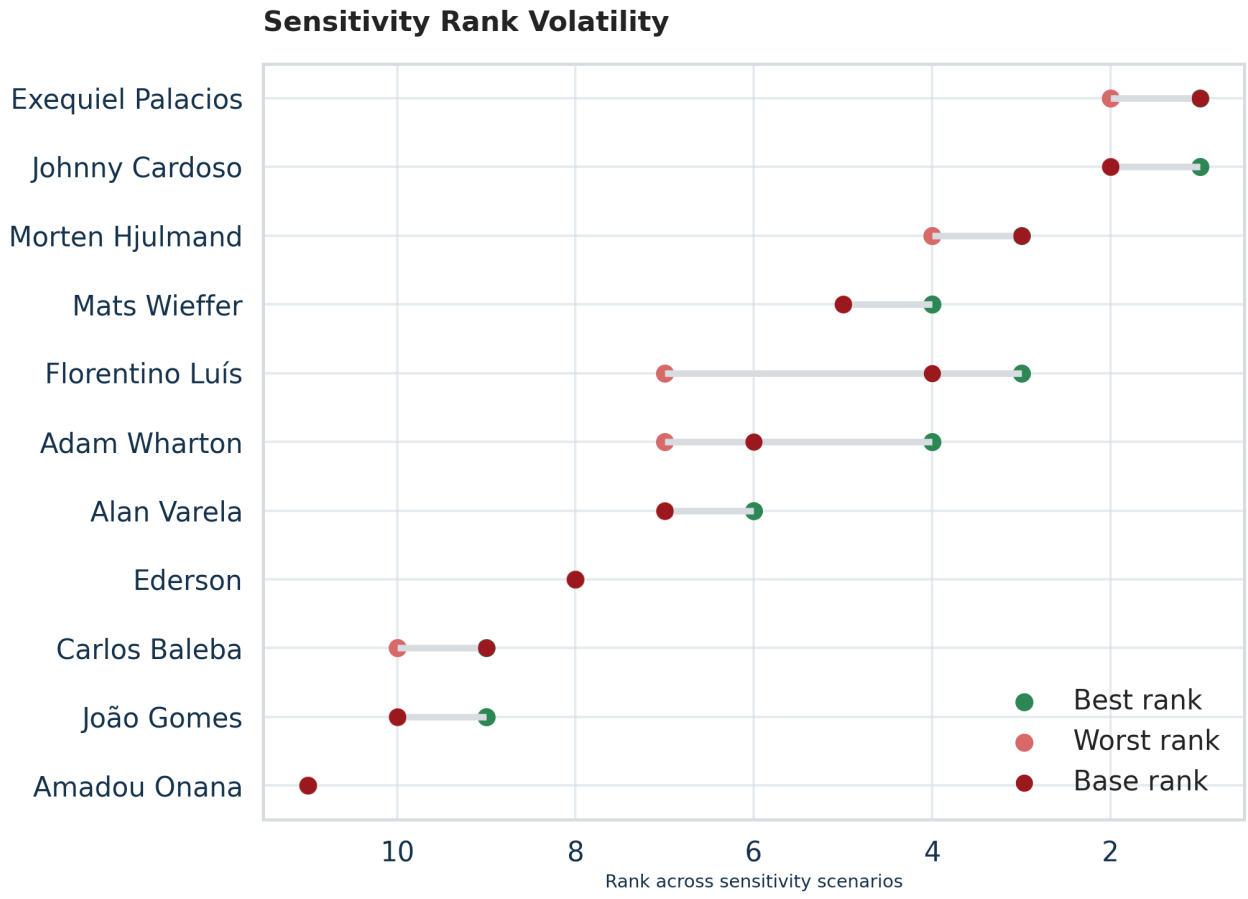
Sensitivity and Practicality

Sensitivity analysis tests whether the shortlist depends too heavily on one subjective weighting choice. A robust candidate remains near the top under several reasonable versions of the model. A fragile candidate ranks highly only when the model favors one specific trait.

Sensitivity analysis is used because the category weights are transparent but still subjective. If a candidate only ranks well under one weighting scheme, the model is telling us that the recommendation is fragile. If a candidate stays high across multiple schemes, the player is a more robust scouting priority.

Lower rank volatility means the player's rank is more stable across weighting scenarios. Average rank should be read alongside volatility, because a player can be stable but still consistently lower-ranked.

If Palacios drops in defensive-heavy scenarios, that confirms he is a control candidate whose defensive translation needs review. If Cardoso stays high across base, defensive-heavy, and possession-heavy scenarios, that supports his two-axis fit. If a player rises only in progression-heavy scenarios, he may be more of a progression specialist than a Casemiro replacement profile. If a player ranks well defensively but poorly in possession-heavy scenarios, he may recreate the original control problem.



Player	Base	Def-heavy	Poss-heavy	Trans-heavy	Prog-heavy	Equal football	Average rank	Rank range	Rank volatility (lower = stabler)
Exequiel Palacios	1	2	1	1	1	1	1.17	1	25.0
Johnny Cardoso	2	1	2	2	2	2	1.83	1	25.0
Morten Hjulmand	3	4	3	3	3	3	3.17	1	25.0
Mats Wieffer	5	5	4	5	5	4	4.67	1	25.0
Florentino Luís	4	3	5	4	7	6	4.83	4	100.0
Adam Wharton	6	7	6	6	4	5	5.67	3	75.0
Alan Varela	7	6	7	7	6	7	6.67	1	25.0
Ederson	8	8	8	8	8	8	8.00	0	0.0
Carlos Baleba	9	10	9	9	9	9	9.17	1	25.0
João Gomes	10	9	10	10	10	10	9.83	1	25.0
Amadou Onana	11	11	11	11	11	11	11.00	0	0.0

Archetype Summary

The model gives the answer. The diagnostic charts explain the answer.

Archetype Summary

Player	Archetype	Strongest	Weakest	Gate margin
Exequiel Palacios	Control profile	Possession Security	Defensive Protection	2.5
Johnny Cardoso	Two-axis defensive/security fit	Defensive Protection	Progressive Value	40.0
Manuel Ugarte	Reference profile - current United player	Defensive Protection	Progressive Value	39.17
Elliot Anderson	Borderline below gate	Progressive Value	Defensive Protection	-2.5
Morten Hjulmand	Context-dependent fit	Defensive Protection	Transition Control	24.17
Florentino Luís	Defensive-floor anchor	Defensive Protection	Progressive Value	50.83
Angelo Stiller	Removed by defensive gate	Possession Security	Defensive Protection	-36.67
Mats Wieffer	Context-dependent fit	Defensive Protection	Transition Control	15.0
Adam Wharton	Context-dependent fit	Progressive Value	Defensive Protection	5.0
Hugo Larsson	Removed by defensive gate	Possession Security	Defensive Protection	-6.25
Alan Varela	Context-dependent fit	Transition Control	Progressive Value	12.5
Aleix García	Removed by defensive gate	Possession Security	Defensive Protection	-38.33

Player	Club	Score	Archetype	Strongest football category	Weakest football category	Gate margin	Analyst note
Exequiel Palacios	Bayer Leverkusen	73.77	Control profile	possession_security	defensive_protection	2.50	Borderline defensive-gate profile; strongest in possession security, weakest in defensive protection. Role and video review should test defensive translation.

Player	Club	Score	Archetype	Strongest football category	Weakest football category	Gate margin	Analyst note
Johnny Cardoso	Atlético Madrid	70.00	Two-axis defensive /security fit	defensive_protection	progressive_value	40.00	Strongest in defensive protection; weakest in progressive value. Use video to test role fit.
Manuel Ugarte	Manchester United	61.70	Reference profile - current United player	defensive_protection	progressive_value	39.17	Current United player used as an internal reference profile, not a target. Strong defence/security base but progression remains the key comparison point.
Elliot Anderson	Nottingham Forest	61.66	Borderline below gate	progressive_value	defensive_protection	-2.50	Below the light defensive gate by 2.5 points; keep for video/context review rather than treating as rejected.
Morten Hjulmand	Sporting CP	58.82	Context-dependent fit	defensive_protection	transition_control	24.17	Strongest in defensive protectio

Player	Club	Score	Archetype	Strongest football category	Weakest football category	Gate margin	Analyst note
							n; weakest in transition control. Use video to test role fit.
Florentino Luís	Burnley	58.54	Defensive-floor anchor	defensive_protection	progressive_value	50.83	Strongest in defensive protection; weakest in progressive value. Use video to test role fit.
Angelo Stiller	Stuttgart	56.68	Removed by defensive gate	possession_security	defensive_protection	-36.67	Below the light defensive gate by 36.7 points; keep for video/context review rather than treating as rejected.
Mats Wieffer	Brighton & Hove Albion	56.57	Context-dependent fit	defensive_protection	transition_control	15.00	Strongest in defensive protection; weakest in transition control. Use video to test role fit.
Adam Wharton	Crystal Palace	54.61	Context-dependent fit	progressive_value	defensive_protection	5.00	Borderline defensive

Player	Club	Score	Archetype	Strongest football category	Weakest football category	Gate margin	Analyst note
							-gate profile; strongest in progressive value, weakest in defensive protection. Role and video review should test defensive translation.
Hugo Larsson	Eintracht Frankfurt	54.29	Removed by defensive gate	possession_security	defensive_protection	-6.25	Below the light defensive gate by 6.2 points; keep for video/context review rather than treating as rejected.
Alan Varela	Porto	53.32	Context-dependent fit	transition_control	progressive_value	12.50	Strongest in transition control; weakest in progressive value. Use video to test role fit.
Aleix García	Bayer Leverkusen	53.21	Removed by defensive gate	possession_security	defensive_protection	-38.33	Below the light defensive gate by 38.3 points; keep for

Player	Club	Score	Archetype	Strongest football category	Weakest football category	Gate margin	Analyst note
							video/context review rather than treating as rejected.

Borderline Watchlist

These players sit within five points below the defensive gate. They are not rejected; they are the names where video, tactical role context, and league translation matter most.

Player	Club	Score	Defence	Security	Progression	Gate margin	Context note
Elliot Anderson	Nottingham Forest	61.66	42.5	67.14	80.83	-2.5	May 2026 EPL target pool: high-cost controller, availability caveat

Role-Mismatch Watchlist

These players remain analytically interesting, but their public-data defensive evidence sits further away from the minimum-evidence filter for this role profile. They may be better fits for different midfield briefs.

Player	Club	Score	Defence	Security	Progression	Gate margin	Context note
Angelo Stiller	Stuttgart	56.68	8.33	95.00	78.33	-36.67	High-volume passer
Hugo Larsson	Eintracht Frankfurt	54.29	38.75	66.43	54.17	-6.25	Bundesliga target pool: young two-way controller
Aleix García	Bayer Leverkusen	53.21	6.67	88.57	83.33	-38.33	Bundesliga target pool: possession controller, lighter duelling profile
Samuele Ricci	AC Milan	49.23	28.75	70.00	34.17	-16.25	Serie A target pool: press-resistant possession profile
Bruno Guimarães	Newcastle United	47.92	27.50	52.14	85.83	-17.50	Control creator, premium market
Youssouf Fofana	AC Milan	38.15	36.25	20.71	67.50	-8.75	Serie A target pool: range, carries, and duels

Limitations

- Public data cannot replace club scouting.
- Aggregate stats lose role, possession, pressure, and team-context detail.
- StatsBomb open data is limited to selected competitions.
- Public statsbombpy access should not be treated as full 360 data access.
- League strength and team style affect metrics.
- Injury history and transfer feasibility require separate work.
- The defensive gate is a screen, not a verdict.

What the Screen Actually Suggests

The screen does not produce one obvious answer. It produces three useful archetypes. Palacios is the control/progression leader but needs defensive translation and availability review. Cardoso is the cleaner two-axis defensive/security fit. Hjulmand, Florentino Luís, and Wieffer preserve more defensive floor but raise different possession or progression questions.

That is the value of the model: it narrows the next scouting conversation rather than pretending to finish it.

Recommended Next Scouting Questions

- **Palacios:** Can his defensive work translate to United's transition-heavy environment? Is his availability/injury history acceptable? Does he receive under pressure in central zones or mainly in cleaner structures?
- **Cardoso:** Does his defensive range hold against Premier League tempo? Can he progress play enough to avoid becoming too conservative?
- **Hjulmand:** Is he clean enough under pressure to solve United's control issue?
- **Florentino Luís:** Is the possession limitation too severe for a control brief?
- **Wieffer:** Does he offer enough mobility and transition coverage?

Built with pandas, matplotlib, public aggregate player statistics, and StatsBomb open-data concepts for event-data role design. This is a screening framework, not a final recruitment decision model.